

10) Provide Transportation:

As people age, they may feel the urge to withdraw and avoid going out. A supportive caregiver provides some normalcy by driving them to social events, as well as their needed medical appointments. Whether it's to pick up books at the library or get them to a much-needed dental cleaning, having the means to get around as they need, and want, will help with providing a healthy quality of life for your loved one.

THE CAREGIVER-CLIENT RELATIONSHIP

The caregiver has a powerful role in the relationship between caregiver and client. This power comes from:

- 1) Control over the services provided to the client
- 2) Access to private knowledge about the client.

It's important not to let the balance of power slide heavily onto the caregiver's side of the relationship. Maintaining professional boundaries helps the caregiver maintain a helpful or "therapeutic" relationship with the client. A good question to ask yourself: Are my actions more about my needs than about the needs of my client? If so, you may be crossing a professional boundary.

To learn more about how to stay in the zone of helpfulness, let's explore the following chart. The chart gives examples of boundary crossings and offers tips for staying in bounds in specific situations.

TYPES OF BOUNDARY CROSSING	HOW TO STAY IN BOUNDS
Sharing Personal Information: It may be tempting to talk to your client about your personal life or problems. Doing so may cause the client to see you as a friend instead of seeing you as a health care professional. As a result, the	• Use caution when talking to a client about your personal life. • Do not share information because you need to talk, or to help you feel better.

client may take on your worries as well as their own.	• Remember that your relationship with your client must be therapeutic, not social.
Not Seeing Behavior as Symptomatic: Sometimes caregivers react emotionally to the actions of a client and forget that those actions are caused by a disorder or disease (symptomatic). Personal emotional responses can cause a caregiver to lose sight of her role or miss important information from a client. In a worst case, it can lead to abuse or neglect of a client.	• Be aware that a client's behavior is the result of a disease or disorder. • Know the client's care plan! • If you are about to respond emotionally or reflexively to the negative behavior of a client, step back and re-approach the client later. • Note that the client may think their action is the best way to solve a problem or fill a need. • Ask yourself if there is a way to problem solve and help the client communicate or react differently.
Nicknames/Endearments: Calling a client 'sweetie' or 'honey' may be comforting to that client, or it might suggest a more personal interest than you intend. It might also point out that you favor one client over another. Some clients may find the use of nicknames or endearments offensive.	• Avoid using terms like honey and sweetie • Ask your client how they would like to be addressed. Some may allow you to use their first name. Others might prefer a more formal approach: Mr., Mrs., Ms., or Miss • Remember that the way you address a client indicates your level of professionalism.
Touch: Touch is a powerful tool. It can be healing and comforting or it can be confusing, hurtful, or simply unwelcome. Touch should be used thoughtfully.	• Use touch only when it will serve a good purpose for the client. • Ask your client if he/she is comfortable with your touch. • Be aware that a client may react differently to touch than you intend. • When using touch, be sure it is serving the client's needs and not your own.
Unprofessional Demeanor: Demeanor includes appearance, tone and volume of voice, speech	• Clients may be frightened or confused by loud voices or fast talk

patterns, body language, etc. Your professional demeanor affects how others perceive you. Personal and professional demeanor may be different.	• Good personal hygiene is a top priority due to close proximity to clients. • Professional attire sends the message that you are serious about your job. • Off-color jokes, racial slurs, profanity are never appropriate. • Body language and facial expressions speak volumes to clients.
Gifts/Tips/Favors: Giving or receiving gifts, or doing special favors, can blur the line between a personal relationship and a professional one. Accepting a gift from a client might be taken as fraud or theft by another person or family member.	• Follow your facility's policy on gifts. • Practice saying no graciously to a resident who offers a gift that is outside your facility's boundaries. • It's ok to tell clients that you are not allowed to accept gifts, tips. • To protect yourself, report offers of unusual or large gifts to your supervisor.
Over-involvement: Signs may include spending inappropriate amounts of time with a particular client, visiting the client when off duty, trading assignments to be with the client, thinking that you are the only caregiver who can meet the client's needs. Under-involvement is the opposite of over-involvement and may include disinterest and neglect.	• Focus on the needs of those in your care, rather than personalities. • Don't confuse the needs of the client with your own needs. • Maintain a helpful relationship, treating each client with the same quality of care and attention, regardless of your emotional reaction to the client. • Ask yourself: Are you becoming overly involved with the client's personal life? If so, discuss your feelings with your supervisor.
Romantic or Sexual Relationships: A caregiver is never permitted to have a romantic or sexual relationship with a client. Sexual	• While it may be normal to be attracted to someone in your care, know that it is never appropriate to act on that attraction.

contact with a client is against the law in Wisconsin because residents of many facilities are not viewed as being able to give consent under the law.	• Do not tell sexually oriented jokes or stories. It may send the wrong message to your client. • Discourage flirting or suggestive behavior by your client. • If you feel that you are becoming attracted to someone in your care, seek help from your supervisor or other trusted professional right away.
Secrets: Secrets between you and a client are different than client confidentiality. Confidential information is shared with a few other members of a team providing care to a resident. Personal secrets compromise role boundaries and can result in abuse or neglect of a client.	• Do not keep personal or health-related secrets with a client. • Remember that your role is to accurately report any changes in your client's condition.

WHY ARE PROFESSIONAL BOUNDARIES IMPORTANT?

Using what you've learned about professional boundaries so far, can you think of some reasons why maintaining professional boundaries is important for caregivers? Below are some of the reasons for maintaining professional boundaries:

- Assures a therapeutic relationship with clients, rather than a social relationship.
- Avoid burnout.
- Avoid legal trouble.
- Maintain a helpful relationship, not too personal and not too aloof.
- Caregivers avoid emotional entanglements.
- Caregivers treat all clients fairly.

- May reduce allegations of caregiver misconduct.
- The caregiver is seen as a professional.
- Supervisors see the caregiver as competent.

WAYS TO IMPROVE CAREGIVER PATIENT RELATIONSHIP

The caregiver/patient relationship can often be tenuous and difficult. Home care is a stressful setting that typically involves great sickness or disability and within that, it is easy for tempers to flare and patience to run thin. This is unfortunate, however, because in addition to being a difficult relationship, the caregiver/patient relationship is also an immensely important one.

In order for quality care and healing to take place, the caregiver and the patient must foster a good relationship, no matter how difficult that may be at times. Here are several steps caregivers and patients can take to improve their relationship and form a genuine bond:

1. Learn to Ask for Help

The caregiver/patient relationship is very intimate and it often involves difficult, confusing or emotionally challenging scenarios. One of the first steps toward high-quality communication and a safe, healing relationship is transparency and the ability to ask for help. This is true for both the patient and the caregiver. In order to build trust, the patient needs to be able to request help when it is needed and, in order to provide quality care, the caregiver needs to be able to ask the patient for help in understanding something new or clarifying a preference or concern. Asking for help is central to communication and communication, in turn, is central to the rest of the caregiver/patient relationship.

2. Exercise Compassion

A home care environment often entails a severely disabled or wounded person who may not have full command of brain function and capacities such as motor skills, memory and speech. These types of disabilities are difficult and can easily create frustration within both the client and the patient.

Frustration, however, leads to a strained and fractured relationship, which is not appropriate for the home care setting. Instead of allowing frustration to take hold, caregivers and patients alike should seek

to exercise compassion. Compassion for self and others allows people to soften their hearts toward another person and get to a place of honest communication.

3. Be Patient.

Patients who have suffered a traumatic brain injury often have difficulty with skills like speech and memory. Additionally, since traumatic brain injuries often affect the part of the brain that deals with response to stimuli, risk-taking and adherence to rules, injured people may exhibit less concern for rules and an increased level of risky or downright dangerous behavior. Patience is the most important virtue a caregiver can have in situations like these. It is important for a caregiver to understand that injured people are not always in complete control of their actions and, with that in mind, to give the person extra time to calm down and make different decisions. This often requires reasoning, positivity and empathy.

4. Use Encouragement.

Encouragement is an underrated soft skill. In addition to motivating patients to behave differently when needed, encouragement also goes a long way toward boosting a patient's self-esteem and making him or her feel capable and in charge once more. Additionally, since being encouraging with patients benefits both the caregiver and the individual, it can rapidly increase the fullness of the relationship.

5. Be an Active Listener.

Each client has a story to tell and learning to truly listen to that story will quickly foster a bond and encourage increased communication and understanding. Additionally, active listening with clients encourages increased rapport and allows the caregiver to better pick up on potential warning signs. When having a conversation with a client, make eye contact and turn your body toward the person speaking. Be careful not to interrupt and ask plenty of good questions to ensure that the client feels heard and respected.

6. Do What the Patient Loves.

Do you have a patient who loves to read but cannot anymore due to poor vision or impaired brain function? Maybe you have a patient who loves puzzles, scrapbooking or board games. Whatever the case may be, make a concerted and honest effort to engage the patient in these pastimes. In addition to

helping a client feel more involved, whole and capable, these activities can go a long way toward decreasing feelings of distress in a patient and encouraging positive changes in behavior.

7. Practice Respect.

Caregivers must have a deep respect for the patient and his or her family. The patient's home is a workplace and must be treated like one. When a caregiver is respectful of a patient's home, belongings and preferences, the patient feels respected in turn, which leads to less distress and an increased feeling of relaxation and comfort. Additionally, practicing constant respect serves to place the patient and the caregiver on the same plane, encouraging increased communication and a deeper relationship. When practices like empathy, active listening, respect, transparency and patience are exercised, both a patient and a client can find themselves in a deep, caring and safe relationship. In a home care setting, these types of relationships are integral in creating healing and comfort. Although home care relationships can be challenging, at times, both patient and caregiver can take a variety of simple steps toward improving the relationship and creating a lasting bond.

8. Take A Break.

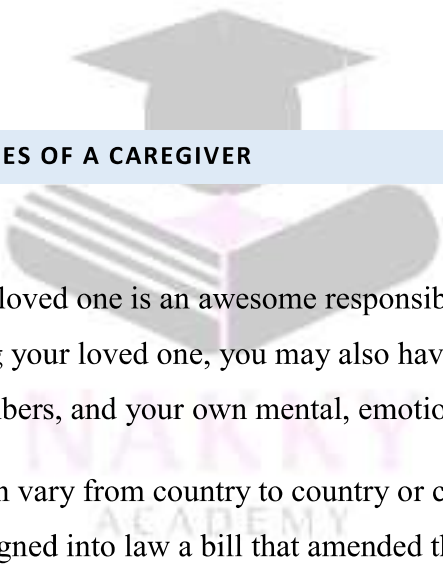
In addition to a few hours or a day of downtime each week, you deserve longer breaks as well. Even if you don't have the finances to take a real vacation, work with your family and members of your patient's family to arrange a full week of time off. Go stay with family or a friend and indulge in staycation treats such as your favorite foods, movies and activities. You may be surprised how restorative a week away can be.

SELF-CARE: THE KEY TO MAINTAINING THE CAREGIVING RELATIONSHIP

It is important for caregivers to take care of themselves. Caregivers who ignore their own needs can be at a higher risk for caregiver burnout as well as physical and mental health problems. It is ok to ask for help. Other ways to care for yourself are:

- Getting enough sleep.

- Eating regular meals.
- Maintaining relationships and activities with other family members and your friends.
- Exercising.
- Doing things, you enjoy (hobbies, meals out, traveling).
- Getting therapy to talk about your experiences as a caregiver.
- Joining a caregiver support group.
- Arranging for respite care for a few days so you can take a more extended break.
- Caregiving can be a rich, rewarding experience that can also be stressful. Try to maintain a balance between your own needs and the needs of others. This helps keep you going.



LEGAL RIGHTS AND RESPONSIBILITIES OF A CAREGIVER

Acting as a caregiver to an elderly loved one is an awesome responsibility. Along with being responsible for obvious things such as assisting your loved one, you may also have other responsibilities, such as your regular job, other family members, and your own mental, emotional, physical, and financial health.

Legal rights of caregivers may even vary from country to country or city to city. For example, New York City's mayor, Bill Blasio, signed into law a bill that amended the New York City Human Rights Law in order to expand its protections to cover caregivers. Employees may now sue employers if the employees are discriminated against or otherwise not accommodated or given leave when they need to give care to a person covered by the law, including their own parents, grandparents, or other relatives, spouses, and others.

You should consult an attorney in your state or city to learn your exact rights in relation to your caregiving responsibilities. This study guide will focus on some of the general concepts of federal law related to a caregiver's legal rights in relation to the workplace.